# Sarasota County Agriculture Education Center

## THE OPPORTUNITY

Sarasota County has an opportunity to create an Agriculture Education Center to grow the agricultural economy and support workforce training for beginning farmers and ranchers and 4-H youth.

A recently acquired property has existing barns, animal pens, pastures and a farmhouse, which, with renovations, could serve as an agricultural demonstration site, a career incubator farm and ranch, while supporting 4-H youth programs and activities.

Before being purchased by Sarasota County, the property had a long history of agriculture, including producing citrus and most recently as a blueberry U-Pick operation. This project will enable continuation of that agricultural heritage for the site and for the community.

## THE VISION

The Sarasota County Agriculture Education Center would create an innovative, hands-on learning environment where aspiring farmers and ranchers could farm small plots for produce, as well as test meat and egg operations in a low-risk environment. They would receive training from UF/IFAS Extension and Sustainability professionals on best practices, plus support for business plans and market development. Partnerships with nonprofits also would enable distribution of products to families facing food insecurity.



## Community Benefits:

- Grow the local economy
- Train workforce
- Educate youth
- Protect agricultural heritage
- Decrease food insecurity
- Preserve the environment

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Sarasota County UF/IFAS Extension and Sustainability | 6600 Clark Road, Sarasota, Florida 34241



## A Valuable Investment






The project also would provide sites for 4-H youth to implement agriculture and horticulture projects, meeting and event space for 4-H clubs, and intergenerational peer learning and mentorship opportunities.

Additionally, it would enable expansion of public educational programming on food systems and the importance of local agriculture. Visitors could meet the farmers, and learn from the demonstration areas, edible gardening classes, and farm-to-table experiences.

## NEXT STEPS

For the Sarasota County Agriculture Education Center to become a reality, the existing facilities and infrastructure, including the barns, animal pens, farmhouse, outbuildings, and fencing, need to be upgraded and renovated to be accessible and hardened against future storms. Equipment and supplies, as well as site work, would be necessary for this location to ultimately serve as a working demonstration and 4-H project farm. An architect is currently developing conceptual designs, while funding is sought for implementation.

## QUESTIONS?

Email **sarasota@ifas.ufl.edu** or call **311** or **941-861-5000.**

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